

Q My baby sleeps all the time. Should I wake him every 3 hours to be fed?

Rest assured that your baby won't starve himself. After your baby's initial alertness following the birth you may be surprised at how much he sleeps and you may worry that he isn't getting enough to eat. In the first few days, your baby only needs small amounts of the pre-milk colostrum. A teaspoon's worth of this thick and creamy, antibody-rich substance that your breasts produce is perfect for his very small tummy. However, it is fairly good practice to put your baby to the breast every two to three hours at first. This is not to get him into a feeding schedule—it's far too early for this—but to help you both develop your technique, and to stimulate your breasts to produce milk. While your first breast milk arrives on average about three to five days after the birth, the more your baby nurses, the faster your milk is likely to "come in."

Q Why does my baby breathe so noisily when he sleeps?

Your baby breathes in and out through his nose only, which means he can breathe comfortably during a long feeding. However it also means that if mucus is blocking his nasal passage, he may snuffle and snort to clear it, or make a wheezing, whistling sound while he breathes. He may gurgle if the mucus makes its way to the back of his throat. Since his air passages are still very small, it's easy for them to get blocked.

Babies also spend about half their sleep time in "active" sleep, when dreams occur, so they tend to be more restless and noisy. Young babies may also have periods during sleep when they stop breathing altogether for a few breaths, which can be for as long as 10 seconds, then revert to shallow and rapid breathing before resuming normal breathing. This "periodic" breathing is especially common in babies born prematurely, but can also occur in full-term babies, and is a passing phase. Noisy breathing that is intermittent is nothing to worry about, but if your baby is persistently noisy, or his breathing seems very labored and fast, he flares his nostrils, makes a barking or rasping sound, his breathing pauses for longer than 10 seconds, or he has a blue tinge to his skin, seek medical guidance.

Q My baby has had his first poop and it was black! Is this normal?

It can be a bit of a shock when you peek inside your newborn's diaper to discover a greenish-black stool. Don't worry—it's a sign of good health.

This greenish-black, tarlike substance is called meconium. It is made up of dead skin cells, lanugo, bilirubin, mucus, and bile that accumulated in your baby's intestines while he was in the uterus and which your baby passes in the first 24 hours.

Although meconium looks a little alarming and is difficult to clean, this first sticky bowel movement is quite normal, and its appearance is a welcome sign that your baby's bowels are in good working order. Your baby's stool will change over the first week or so as he settles into feeding. If you are concerned at all speak to your pediatrician.



Bowel movements When you change your baby's diaper it is normal to find stools of differing colors.

WHAT DOES A NORMAL DIAPER LOOK LIKE?

It's often news to first-time parents that baby stools come in a whole range of colors and textures. So knowing what's normal (most of it), and what isn't quite right will stop you from worrying each time you look in your baby's diaper. Here's what you can expect:

» **In the first couple of days,** your baby will pass meconium, the thick, green-black, tarlike substance that accumulated in his bowels while in the uterus.



» **From days three to five,** stools gradually change, turning from dark green through to yellow and light brown.



» **Your breast-fed baby's** stools will be a mustardlike color and may be seedy and watery. They are also surprisingly sweet smelling.



» **Your formula-fed baby's** stools tend to be more formed and a slightly darker yellow-tan color. Some formula can lend a greenish color to stools.



» **In the first few days,** your baby may poop frequently, sometimes after each feeding. After about day four, your baby will usually pass around two stools a day for the next few weeks. Breast-fed babies sometimes pass stools less often, and may occasionally go several days without a bowel movement. As long as the stools are soft and not uncomfortable for your baby to pass, this isn't a concern.